

PRACTICAL SKILLS FOR PHARMACISTS

ASSERTIVENESS

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What is Assertiveness?

- Assertiveness is the ability to stand up for ourselves and to say how we feel when we feel and we need to.
- It includes:
 - Expressing your own opinion and feelings
 - Saying "no" without feeling guilty
 - Setting your own priorities
 - Asking for what you want
 - Being able to take reasonable risks

Cont...

- Assertiveness is the ability to express yourself openly and honestly and reflecting a genuine concern for others.
- However, asserting yourself will not necessarily guarantee your happiness or fair treatment by others.
- Just because you assert yourself does not mean you will always get what you want.

Cont...

- Assertive style is recommended for pharmacists
- They operate from the belief that each person is responsible for solving his or her own problems, and neither party in communication has to justify themselves to each other
- They take responsibility for their own decisions and actions
- Assertiveness is best understood by comparing it with two other response styles:
 - Passivity and Aggression

PASSIVE BEHAVIOR

- This response is designed to avoid conflict at all cost.
- Passive individuals “hide” from people and wait for others to initiate conversation.
- They put the needs or wants of other people above their own.
- They worry about how others will respond to them and have a high need for approval.

AGGRESSIVE BEHAVIOR

- Aggressive people seek to “win” in conflict situations by dominating or intimidating others.
- They promote their own interests but are hostile to the feelings, thoughts, or needs of others.
- Such individuals are easily angered and have a low tolerance for frustration.

Theoretical Foundations

- Behaviorists believe that passive or aggressive responses have been reinforced or rewarded and thus strengthened.
- Aggressive behavior often works in the short term because others feel intimidated and allow aggressive persons to get what they want.
- Passive behaviors are reinforced when individuals are able to escape or even avoid conflict in relationships and thus escape the anxiety that surrounds these conflicts.

Cont...

- ❑ Cognitive theories hold that people respond passively or aggressively b/c they have irrational beliefs that interfere with assertiveness.

These beliefs involve:

1. Fear of rejection or anger from others and need for approval
 - ✓ (everyone should like me and approve of what I do),
2. Over-concern for the needs and rights of others
 - ✓ (I should always try to help others and be nice to them),
3. Belief that problems with assertiveness are due to unalterable personality characteristics and are, therefore, unchangeable

Assertiveness Techniques

- There are a number of communication techniques or strategies that are useful in responding to situations that tend to be conflict-ridden.

PROVIDING FEEDBACK

- Letting others know how you respond to their behavior can help to avoid misunderstandings and also help to resolve the conflicts that are inevitable in relationships.
- However, providing honest feedback is difficult to accomplish without hurting feelings.

Cont...

- ❑ Many times, you must tell people that you are upset by what they did in order to improve your relationship in the long run.
- ❑ When you choose to convey feedback to others, use techniques to make the communication less threatening.

Cont...

Criteria for useful feedback include:

- Feedback focuses on a person's behavior rather than personality (something the individual can change)
- Feedback is descriptive rather than evaluative. Describing what was said or done is less threatening than judging why you assume it was done.
 - Feedback is specific rather than general (e.g., “you always do”).
 - Feedback focuses on problem solving.
 - Feedback is provided in a private setting.

INVITING FEEDBACK FROM OTHERS

- ❑ We need to invite feedback from others in order to improve our interpersonal communication skills.
- ❑ Develop your ability to
 - Hear criticism or suggestions without defensiveness or anger,
 - Admit when you have made a mistake,
 - Encourage feedback from others that encourage people to be honest in their communications with you.

SETTING LIMITS

- For some of us, setting limits on how we will spend our personal time and money is a source of frustration.
 - ✓ We have difficulty of saying “no” to any request.
- Being assertive in setting limits does not mean that you stop saying “yes” to requests.
 - ✓ You will continue to help others, even though doing so may be an inconvenience

Cont...

- When faced with a request, the first step is to decide how much you are willing to do in meeting the request.
 - If you need time to decide, delaying a response is appropriate as long as you get back to the person within the specified time frame.
- Whether you give reasons or not, does not change the fact that you have the right to make the decision on how you will spend personal time and financial resources.

MAKING REQUESTS

- Asking for what you want from others in a direct manner is necessary in healthy relationships.
- If you are in a management position, clearly communicating your expectations of others is an important part of carrying out the goals of the organization.

Cont...

- In equal relationships, making requests, including asking for help, is an important part of honest communication.
- We must trust others will be able to respond to our requests in an assertive manner, including saying “no.”
- Thus, we must not over- react when someone turns down our request in an assertive way.

BEING PERSISTENT

- ❑ One important aspect of being assertive is to be persistent in assuring that your rights are respected.
- ❑ This will stop even the most manipulative person without assigning blame or escalating the conflict.

IGNORING PROVOCATIONS

- ❑ Interpersonal conflict may elicit various ways of trying to “win” by attempting to humiliate or intimidate others.
- ❑ Pharmacists who feel unfairly criticized may respond in an aggressive manner.
- ❑ Interpersonal conflicts between health professionals are often marked by struggles for power and autonomy (often called “turf battles”).

Cont...

- Ignoring the critical comments of others and focusing on solving underlying problems can do much to keep conflict from escalating.
- Accepting ,disagreeing, delaying response, fogging

FOGGING....involves acknowledging the truth or possible truths in what people tell you

- ✓ about yourself while ignoring completely any judgments they might have implied

RESPONDING TO CRITICISM

□ For some of us, criticism is particularly devastating b/c we typically hold two common irrational beliefs that:

1. We must be loved or approved of by virtually everyone we know
2. We must be completely competent in everything we do and never make mistakes.

How do assertiveness problems relate to your ability to function more effectively as a pharmacist?

- Let's examine a few typical situations in pharmacy practice and determine what might be the most assertive way to respond in relationships with
 - Patients,
 - Physicians,
 - Employees,
 - Employers, and
 - Colleagues.

Assertiveness and Patients

- The most important assertive skill relating to patients is your willingness to initiate communication.
- Some pharmacists hide behind the counter, give prescriptions to clerks to hand to patients, and generally avoid interaction with patients unless asked specific questions.

Cont...

- Assertive pharmacists come out
 - From behind counters,
 - Introduce themselves to patients,
 - Provide information on medications, and
 - Assess the patient's use of medications and problems with therapy.
 - Encouraging patients to be more assertive

Assertiveness and Other Health Care Professionals

- When problems in patient medication therapies arise, consultations with physicians or nurses are often required.
- Messages transmitted through third parties may not be the most effective means of communication.

CASE STUDY

PHARMACIST CALLING A NURSE IN A PHYSICIAN'S OFFICE

Pharmacist: This is Hailu, the pharmacist at Central Pharmacy. I'd like to speak to Dr. Abebe please.

Nurse: He's with a patient right now. What is it you wish to speak to him about?

Pharmacist: I am concerned about Mrs. Jemila's prescription for metformin. I need to speak to Dr. Abebe about it. Please have him call me as soon as he comes out from the patient examination.

Nurse: It might be quicker if you tell me what the problem is. I could talk to Dr. Abebe and get back to you.

Pharmacist: Thank you, but in this case, I would like to talk to Dr. Abebe directly.

Nurse: He's very busy today and we're running behind schedule.

Pharmacist: I know he has a busy schedule but I must speak with him as soon as possible. Please ask him to call.

Cont...

- The pharmacist in this communication was assertive. He showed respect for the nurse and yet was persistent in stating his request.
- He did not argue about the issue of which method of communication was quicker.
- He calmly restated his request without anger or apology.

Assertiveness with Employees

- Talk in private
- Be specific in your approach to the problem
- Do not become defensive
- Positive feedback is as important as negative feedback

Assertiveness with Employers

- Five responses that are helpful in situations of criticism:
 - Getting useful feedback
 - Agreeing with criticism
 - Disagreeing with criticism
 - Fogging (example)
 - Delaying a response

Assertiveness with Colleagues

- The best response is to ‘delay’ your response
- For example, the president of your local pharmacy association calls and asks you to serve as chairman of a new committee.

You are interested in the committee but are not sure you have the time to chair it.

- ✓ “I’m interested in the committee, but I’m not sure I have time. Let me think about it tonight and I’ll call you in the morning with my decision.”

Summary

- Assertiveness is a response style that focuses on resolving conflicts in relationships in an atmosphere of mutual respect
- Assertiveness gives the person the ability to directly and honestly convey what they think
- Allows people to stand up for their own rights and what they believe in without fringing on the rights of others
- Focus on problem solving

Reading Assignment

- Small-Group Communication
- Public Communication

Thank you !!